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2.4 Human Rights (OCR Component 2)

This topic explores the geographical dimensions of human rights: how rights are distributed unevenly across the world, the factors that influence their protection or violation, and the role of different actors in promoting them. It covers development indicators, health and education inequalities, gender disparities, and debates about sovereignty versus intervention. The geographical lens focuses on spatial patterns, scale, and the connections between rights, development, and power.

1. Geographies of Human Rights

Human rights: Fundamental rights and freedoms inherent to all human beings, regardless of race, sex, nationality, ethnicity, language, religion, or any other status. They include: (1) civil and political rights (freedoms FROM state interference — freedom of speech, assembly, religion, right to a fair trial, right to vote); and (2) economic, social, and cultural rights (entitlements TO resources — right to health, education, adequate standard of living, work, cultural participation).

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)

Adopted by the UN General Assembly on 10 December 1948 in Paris, the UDHR was drafted in response to the atrocities of World War II and the Holocaust. It established, for the first time, a common standard of fundamental rights for all peoples and nations. Eleanor Roosevelt chaired the drafting committee. The UDHR contains 30 articles.

Article	Right	Geographical Significance
Article 3	Right to life, liberty, and security of person	Violated in conflict zones (Syria, Yemen, DRC, Myanmar); threatened by environmental hazards and climate change; undermined by state violence and police brutality

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Article 13	Freedom of movement within and between states	Restricted by border controls, walls (US-Mexico, Israel-Palestine), refugee policies; completely suppressed in North Korea (citizens cannot leave); internal movement restricted in China (hukou system)
Article 19	Freedom of opinion and expression	Suppressed in authoritarian states; China's Great Firewall blocks Google, Facebook, Twitter for 1.4 billion people; journalists murdered at rate of ~50/year globally; press freedom declining in 70% of countries (RSF, 2023)
Article 25	Right to adequate standard of living (food, housing, healthcare, social services)	Not met for billions: 735 million people face chronic hunger; 1.6 billion lack adequate housing; 2 billion lack safely managed drinking water. Directly linked to development level and inequality
Article 26	Right to education	244 million children and youth out of school globally; 130+ million girls denied education; conflict disrupts schooling for 75 million children. Taliban ban on girls' secondary education in Afghanistan

The UDHR is not legally binding, but it has inspired over 80 legally binding international treaties and conventions, including:

- **International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR, 1966):** 173 states parties; covers freedom of speech, religion, assembly, right to a fair trial
- **International Covenant on Economic, Social, and Cultural Rights (ICESCR, 1966):** 171 states parties; covers right to work, health, education, adequate living standard
- **Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC, 1989):** Most widely ratified human rights treaty (196 states; only non-ratifier is the USA)
- **Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW, 1979):** 189 states parties; addresses gender-based discrimination

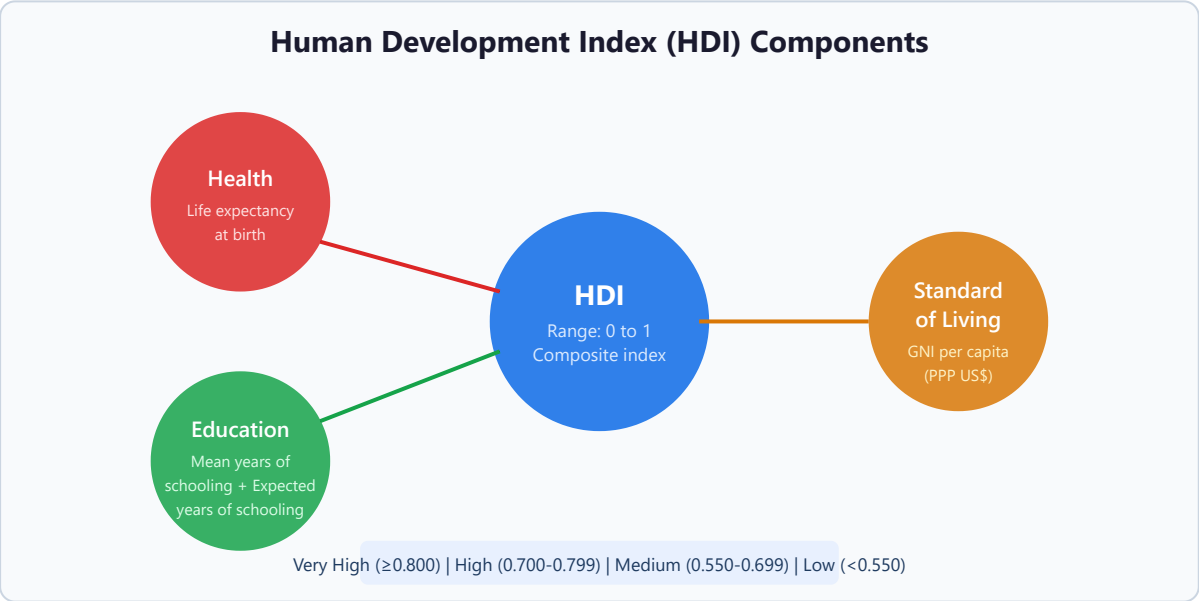
Exam Tip: Distinguish between civil/political rights (freedoms FROM interference — speech, assembly, fair trial) and economic/social/cultural rights (entitlements TO resources — health, education, housing). Western democracies traditionally prioritise civil/political rights; socialist/developing states often prioritise economic/social rights. This tension is central to debates

about universalism vs cultural relativism. Some governments argue that economic development must come before political freedoms; critics counter that both sets of rights are indivisible and interdependent.

2. Development Indicators and Inequality

Development: The process of improving the quality of life and economic well-being of a population. Development is multidimensional: it encompasses economic growth (rising GDP), social progress (improved health, education, equality), environmental sustainability, and political freedom. Amartya Sen defined development as the expansion of human capabilities and freedoms — not merely income growth.

Key Development Indicators

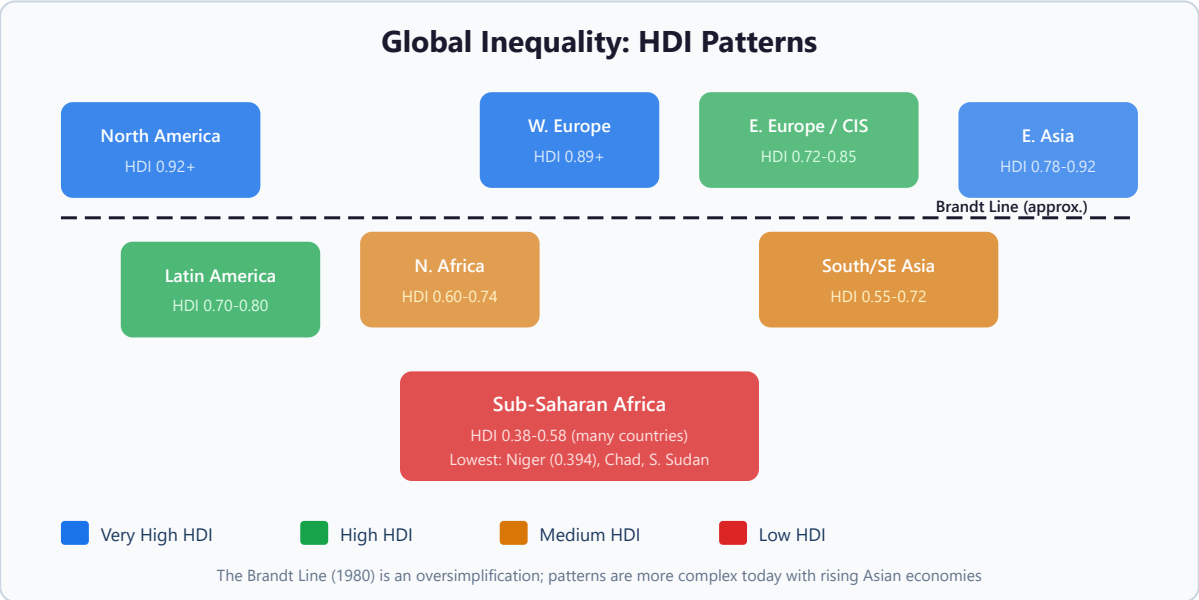


Indicator	What It Measures	Strengths	Limitations
HDI	Composite of health (life expectancy), education (mean and expected years of schooling), and income	Multidimensional; updated annually; allows international comparison; goes	National averages hide internal inequalities (regional, gender, ethnic); does not capture rights, freedoms, or environmental

	(GNI per capita PPP). Scale 0–1	beyond purely economic measures	sustainability; data quality variable in LICs
GNI per capita (PPP)	Average income per person adjusted for purchasing power parity (what money can actually buy locally)	Enables meaningful international comparison; accounts for cost of living differences	Averages hide extreme income inequality; informal/subsistence economy not captured; says nothing about distribution
Gini coefficient	Income inequality within a country. 0 = perfect equality; 1 = perfect inequality. Most countries range from 0.25 (Scandinavia) to 0.65 (South Africa)	Direct, comparable measure of inequality; highlights distribution not just average wealth	Does not reveal absolute poverty levels (a poor country could have low inequality); different methodologies complicate comparison
GDI (Gender Development Index)	Ratio of female to male HDI values — measures gender gaps in health, education, and income	Highlights gender-specific disparities within countries; allows international gender comparison	Only three dimensions; binary gender framework; does not capture legal or political dimensions of gender inequality
GII (Gender Inequality Index)	Measures gender-based disadvantage in three dimensions: reproductive health, empowerment (education + parliament), and labour market participation	Broader than GDI; captures political empowerment and reproductive health	Limited dimensions; data gaps in many LICs

MPI (Multidimensional Poverty Index)	Measures overlapping deprivations across 10 indicators in health, education, and living standards. A person is MPI-poor if deprived in at least one-third of weighted indicators	Captures multiple dimensions simultaneously; identifies the poorest of the poor; can be disaggregated by region, age, ethnicity	Complex methodology; data availability variable; household-level data may miss individual deprivation (especially women within households)
IHDI (Inequality-adjusted HDI)	Adjusts HDI for internal inequality in each dimension. The greater the inequality, the larger the "loss" from the standard HDI	Directly shows how inequality reduces development gains; reveals hidden disparities within countries	Requires detailed distributional data; not available for all countries

Global Inequality Patterns



Key patterns of global inequality:

- **North-South divide:** The Brandt Line (1980) identified a broad division between wealthier nations in the global North and poorer nations in the South. This persists in broad terms but is increasingly complicated by: the rise of China, India, and other Asian economies; oil-wealthy Gulf states; persistent

poverty in parts of the "North" (rural Appalachia, post-industrial northern England); and growing middle classes in "Southern" countries

- **Intra-country inequality:** Often greater than inter-country inequality. Examples: coastal vs inland China (Shanghai's GDP per capita is 6x that of Gansu province); northern vs southern Nigeria (the north has HDI levels comparable to the poorest African countries while Lagos competes with middle-income nations); London vs northern England (life expectancy gap of 10+ years between Kensington and Blackpool)
- **Gender inequality:** Women face systemic disadvantage in many regions, particularly South Asia, Sub-Saharan Africa, and the Middle East/North Africa. Gender gaps in education, income, political representation, and legal rights persist globally
- **Ethnic and indigenous minorities:** Indigenous peoples and ethnic minorities face discrimination in access to land, services, education, and political representation in virtually every country. Australia's indigenous population has life expectancy 8 years lower than non-indigenous Australians; Brazil's indigenous peoples face ongoing land dispossession in the Amazon

3. Health Inequalities

Global Health Disparities

Health outcomes are among the starkest indicators of global inequality. Life expectancy varies by over 30 years between the highest-performing countries (Japan: 84.8 years; Switzerland: 83.4) and the lowest (Central African Republic: 53.3; Chad: 52.5; South Sudan: 55.0).

Health Issue	Global Pattern	Contributing Factors
Maternal mortality	Sub-Saharan Africa accounts for 66% of global maternal deaths. Lifetime risk: 1 in 37 in Sub-Saharan Africa vs 1 in 7,800 in Europe. Sierra Leone: 1,120 deaths per 100,000 live births vs UK: 10 per 100,000	Lack of skilled birth attendants; poor obstetric infrastructure; distance to facilities (average 25 km in rural SSA); malnutrition; teenage pregnancy; lack of family planning; cultural barriers to seeking care
Child mortality	Under-5 mortality is 14x higher in LICs than HICs (67/1,000 vs 5/1,000). 5 million children under 5 die annually; 50% in	Poverty; contaminated water (780 million people lack clean water); limited vaccination coverage; malnutrition

	Sub-Saharan Africa. Most deaths are from preventable causes (pneumonia 15%, diarrhoea 8%, malaria 5%, neonatal conditions 47%)	(causing 45% of child deaths); lack of trained health workers
HIV/AIDS	Sub-Saharan Africa has 65% of the 39 million global cases. Southern and Eastern Africa most affected (Eswatini: 27% prevalence; South Africa: 19%). AIDS has reduced life expectancy by 10+ years in the worst-affected countries	Poverty; gender inequality (women 2x more likely to be infected); stigma preventing testing; limited healthcare access; cultural practices; insufficient antiretroviral treatment (though coverage has improved dramatically from 3% in 2003 to 75% in 2022)
Non-communicable diseases (NCDs)	NCDs (heart disease, cancer, diabetes, respiratory disease) now cause 74% of global deaths. Rising rapidly in LICs/MICs due to urbanisation, dietary changes, and tobacco use. The "double burden of disease" in MICs: infectious diseases persist while NCDs increase	Tobacco use (8 million deaths/year); unhealthy diets; physical inactivity; air pollution (7 million deaths/year); alcohol; ageing populations; limited NCD screening and treatment in LICs
Mental health	1 billion people globally affected; LICs spend less than 1% of health budgets on mental health; 75% of people with mental disorders in LMICs receive no treatment. Only 2 psychiatrists per 100,000 people in LMICs (vs 13 in HICs)	Stigma; lack of trained professionals; underfunding; conflict and displacement (70% of refugees experience mental health difficulties); poverty and social exclusion

Case Study: Health Inequalities in Sierra Leone

Sierra Leone consistently ranks among the world's poorest performers on health indicators, illustrating the intersection of poverty, conflict, governance, and health:

- **Key statistics:** Life expectancy ~55 years (vs UK ~81); maternal mortality 1,120/100,000 live births (115x the UK rate); under-5 mortality 109/1,000 (22x UK); 0.02 doctors per 1,000 people (vs UK: 2.8 — 140x fewer); GDP per capita ~$500
- **Historical context:** The civil war (1991–2002) destroyed 70% of health infrastructure; killed 50,000 people and displaced 2.6 million. Health worker flight (brain drain) during and after the

war decimated the medical workforce

- **Ebola crisis (2014–2016):** 14,124 cases, 3,956 deaths in Sierra Leone. The epidemic overwhelmed the health system (which had only ~120 doctors for 7 million people), collapsed routine healthcare (vaccination, maternal care, malaria treatment), and caused an estimated 10,600 additional deaths from other causes due to health system failure. International response was slow; MSF called for military-level deployment months before it arrived
- **Ongoing challenges:** Chronic underfunding (government health spending ~$9 per person/year vs WHO recommendation of $86); 80% of healthcare provided by NGOs (MSF, Partners in Health, WHO); shortage of equipment, drugs, and trained staff; rural populations often 25+ km from nearest health facility; cultural practices (traditional birth attendants vs skilled midwives)
- **Progress:** Free Healthcare Initiative (2010) removed user fees for pregnant women, lactating mothers, and children under 5, increasing utilisation. Polio eradicated. But structural poverty remains the fundamental barrier

4. Education Access and Inequality

Education access: The ability of individuals to participate in formal education systems. Barriers include: direct costs (school fees, uniforms, books), opportunity costs (lost income from child labour), distance to school, quality of teaching, cultural attitudes (especially towards girls' education), conflict and insecurity, disability, and language (instruction in non-native languages).

Global Education Patterns

- **Primary education:** Near-universal enrolment in most regions (global net enrolment ~90%), but completion rates remain low in Sub-Saharan Africa (~65%) and South Asia (~82%). Quality varies enormously: in many LICs, children attend school but learn very little (the "learning crisis" — World Bank estimates 53% of children in LMICs cannot read a simple story by age 10)
- **Secondary education:** Significant gender and wealth gaps persist. In Sub-Saharan Africa, only 35% of girls complete lower secondary school. In Chad and Niger, fewer than 5% of the poorest girls complete secondary education. Rural-urban divides are stark: urban secondary completion rates are often 3–5x higher than rural rates

- **Tertiary education:** Highly concentrated in HICs and urban areas of MICs. Gross enrolment in tertiary education: 80%+ in North America and Europe vs ~9% in Sub-Saharan Africa. Brain drain further disadvantages LICs as their best-educated graduates emigrate
- **Literacy:** Global adult literacy ~87%, but below 40% in some LICs (Niger: 35%, Mali: 35%, South Sudan: 35%). Female literacy lags behind male literacy in many regions: in South Asia, the female literacy rate is 10+ percentage points below the male rate; in some West African countries, the gap exceeds 20 points
- **Impact of COVID-19:** School closures affected 1.6 billion learners at their peak (2020). Learning losses were greatest in LICs where online alternatives were unavailable (only 6% of households in Sub-Saharan Africa have internet access). UNICEF estimates 10 million additional girls may never return to school

Case Study: Girls' Education in Afghanistan

Afghanistan represents the most extreme contemporary example of state-imposed educational exclusion:

- **Taliban ban:** Since August 2021, the Taliban have banned girls above age 12 from secondary education and women from university. This is the only country in the world where girls are barred from secondary school by government policy
- **Scale:** Over 1.1 million girls directly affected. Before the Taliban takeover, significant progress had been made since 2001: female enrolment grew from near-zero to 3.5 million girls in school; female literacy rose from 17% to 30%
- **Consequences:** Increased rates of child marriage (girls married off because schooling is no longer an option — UNICEF estimates 28% of Afghan girls married before 18); reduced economic opportunity (women excluded from most employment); poorer health outcomes (educated mothers have lower child mortality rates); intergenerational poverty; psychological harm (depression, anxiety among excluded girls)
- **International response:** Universal condemnation from UN, Western governments, and Muslim-majority countries alike. The Organisation of Islamic Cooperation declared the ban un-Islamic. But: diplomatic pressure has been ineffective. No country has recognised the Taliban government. Foreign aid (which funded 75% of government spending pre-2021) has been largely frozen, but this harms the population more than the regime
- **Broader significance:** Illustrates the limits of international pressure on sovereign states; demonstrates that rights gains can be reversed rapidly; highlights the political instrumentalisation of education and gender

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5. Gender Inequality

Gender inequality: The unequal treatment, status, or opportunities available to individuals based on their gender. It manifests across economic opportunities, political representation, education access, health outcomes, legal protections, and personal freedoms. Gender inequality is not confined to LICs — it persists in all societies, though its forms and severity vary greatly.

Measuring Gender Inequality

Index	What It Measures	Key Findings
Gender Development Index (GDI)	Gender gaps in HDI achievement (health, education, income). Ratio of female to male HDI	Most equal: Northern Europe (Iceland, Norway, Finland); least equal: parts of Sub-Saharan Africa (Chad, Niger, Mali), South Asia (Afghanistan, Pakistan)
Gender Inequality Index (GII)	Three dimensions: reproductive health (maternal mortality, adolescent birth rate), empowerment (women in parliament, secondary education), and labour force participation	Best performers: Switzerland (0.025), Denmark, Sweden; worst: Yemen (0.820), Chad, Papua New Guinea. The lower the GII, the more equal
Global Gender Gap Index (WEF)	Four pillars: economic participation, educational attainment, health and survival, political empowerment. Measures the gap between women and men as a ratio	At current rates, global gender parity would take 131 years to achieve. No country has achieved full parity. Iceland ranks 1st (90.8% gap closed); Afghanistan ranks last

Forms of Gender Inequality

- **Economic:** Globally, women earn approximately 77 cents for every dollar earned by men (unadjusted pay gap). Women perform 76% of unpaid care and domestic work (worth an estimated $10.8 trillion/year if valued at minimum wage). In many LICs, women cannot own land, inherit property, or access credit. Only 55% of women globally participate in the labour force vs 80% of men

- **Education:** 130 million girls are out of school globally. In South Sudan, only 1% of girls complete secondary school. But: in many HICs and MICs, girls now outperform boys educationally (in the UK, girls outperform boys at every level from GCSE to university)
- **Health:** 287,000 women die annually from preventable pregnancy and childbirth causes (800/day). Female genital mutilation (FGM) affects 200+ million women in 30+ countries. Sex-selective abortion has produced 140+ million "missing women" in Asia (China, India). Women live longer than men in most countries but face higher rates of disability and morbidity
- **Political:** Women hold only 26.5% of parliamentary seats globally (2023). Only 28 countries have ever had a female head of state/government. Women are excluded from politics entirely in some contexts (Saudi Arabia only granted women the right to vote in 2015; Taliban-ruled Afghanistan bars women from public life)
- **Legal:** In 49 countries, there are no laws specifically addressing domestic violence. In some jurisdictions, women cannot travel freely, work, or open a bank account without male permission. Marital rape remains legal in 36 countries. In many countries, inheritance and divorce laws heavily favour men
- **Violence:** 1 in 3 women globally experiences physical or sexual violence in her lifetime. Conflict-related sexual violence is used systematically as a weapon of war (documented in DRC, Bosnia, Myanmar, Iraq)

Case Study: Gender Inequality in India

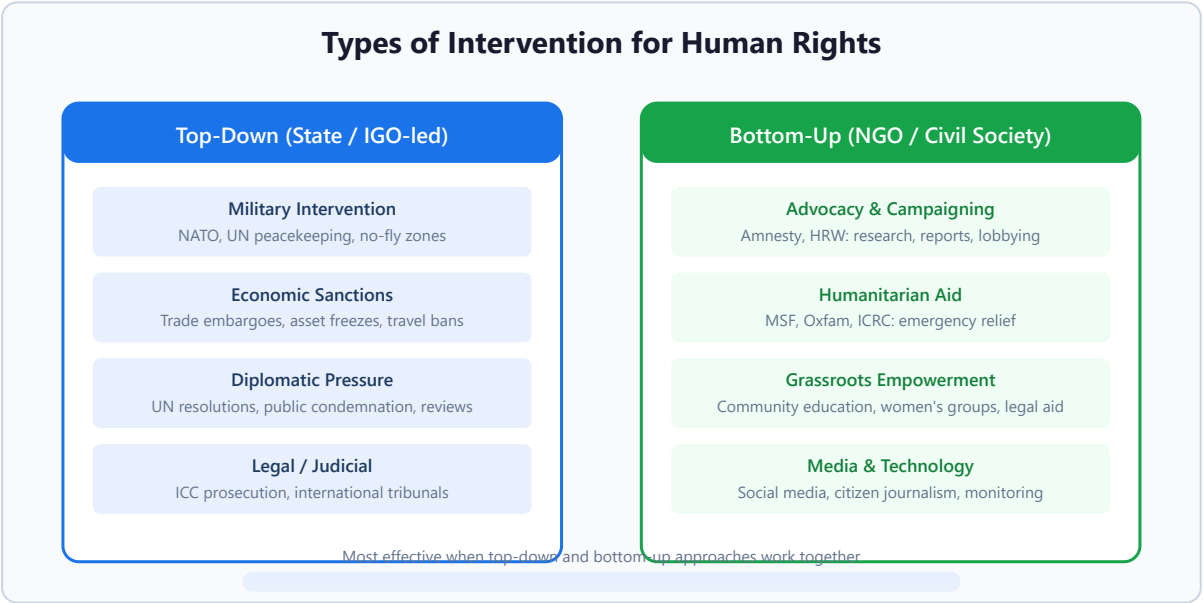
India ranks 122 out of 162 countries on the GII, despite being the world's 5th largest economy:

- **Son preference:** Deep-rooted cultural preference for sons has led to sex-selective abortions (despite being illegal since 1994) and produced a skewed sex ratio: 108 males per 100 females nationally, reaching 120:100 in some northern states (Haryana, Punjab). An estimated 63 million women are "missing" from India's population
- **Economic participation:** Female labour force participation has declined from 32% to 21% over recent decades (one of the world's lowest rates). Women own only 12.8% of land. The gender pay gap is 27% even in formal sector employment
- **Education:** Female literacy (65%) lags behind male literacy (82%). In rural Rajasthan and Bihar, female literacy is below 50%. However, at university level, female enrolment has risen dramatically and now exceeds male enrolment in many states
- **Violence:** A woman is raped every 15 minutes in India (official statistics, widely considered underestimates). Dowry-related deaths: ~7,000 per year. Acid attacks, honour killings, and

trafficking remain widespread. The 2012 Delhi gang rape case prompted national outrage and some legal reform

- **Government responses:** Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (Save the Daughter, Educate the Daughter) scheme targets son preference through awareness campaigns and financial incentives. Reservation of 33% of local government seats for women (73rd Constitutional Amendment). Criminalisation of dowry, child marriage, and FGM. Maternity Benefit Act (2017) extended paid maternity leave to 26 weeks
- **Limitations:** Laws exist but enforcement is weak. Police frequently refuse to register complaints of violence against women. Judicial processes are slow (average rape case takes 5+ years). Deep-rooted patriarchal cultural norms change slowly. Rural-urban divide remains vast

6. The Role of IGOs and NGOs in Promoting Human Rights



Key Organisations and Their Roles

Organisation	Human Rights Role	Effectiveness
United Nations	UN Human Rights Council (47 members, rotating) monitors abuses through Universal Periodic Review; UNHCR protects refugees; UNICEF	Global legitimacy and moral authority. But: hampered by P5 veto power (Russia and China routinely block action on Syria, Myanmar, etc.); under-resourced; recommendations are often

	protects children; Security Council can authorise sanctions or intervention; Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) investigates violations	non-binding; states with the worst records sometimes sit on the Human Rights Council (Saudi Arabia, China)
International Criminal Court (ICC)	Prosecutes individuals for genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity, and aggression. Based in The Hague. 123 member states	Symbolic importance: first permanent international criminal court. Has issued arrest warrants for heads of state (Omar al-Bashir of Sudan, Vladimir Putin of Russia). But: major powers (USA, China, Russia, India) are not members; enforcement depends entirely on state cooperation; accused of disproportionately targeting African leaders; slow proceedings (average case takes 10+ years)
European Court of Human Rights	Enforces European Convention on Human Rights (ECHR) for 46 member states of the Council of Europe. Individuals can bring cases against states	Binding judgments with strong compliance record (though declining). Has expanded rights protection significantly in areas including LGBTQ+ rights, prisoner rights, and freedom of expression. But: limited to European context; some states resist judgments (Russia was expelled in 2022; UK government has repeatedly considered withdrawing)
Amnesty International	Research, campaigning, and advocacy. Publishes annual State of the World's Human Rights report documenting abuses in 155+ countries. Campaigns on specific prisoners of conscience, abolition of torture, and death penalty	Highly influential: reports are widely cited by media, governments, and other NGOs. Shaming tactics can pressure governments. But: no enforcement power; depends on media attention; can be accused of Western bias
MSF (Doctors Without Borders)	Provides emergency medical humanitarian aid in conflict zones, epidemics, and natural disasters.	Delivers life-saving healthcare where no one else can or will operate. Nobel Peace Prize (1999). Also acts as witness (temoignage):

	Operates in 70+ countries with 63,000+ staff. Principles: independence, impartiality, neutrality	publicly denounces atrocities it observes. Limitations: access denied by some governments; staff killed (49 killed in 2019 alone); treats symptoms not structural causes

7. Intervention and Its Consequences

The Sovereignty vs. Intervention Debate

The central tension in human rights geography: state sovereignty (the principle that states have exclusive authority within their borders and cannot be interfered with by external actors) vs. the international community's moral and legal responsibility to protect populations from mass atrocities.

Responsibility to Protect (R2P): A political commitment adopted unanimously by UN member states at the 2005 World Summit. It states that: (1) every state has the responsibility to protect its population from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity; (2) the international community should assist states in meeting this obligation; (3) if a state manifestly fails to protect its population, the international community should take collective action through the UN Security Council, including (as a last resort) military intervention.

Arguments for Intervention	Arguments Against Intervention
Moral duty to prevent genocide and mass atrocities — the lessons of Rwanda (1994) and the Holocaust demand action	Violates state sovereignty and the principle of non-interference in internal affairs (UN Charter Article 2(7))
R2P doctrine creates a framework for legitimate, multilateral intervention when states fail to protect their people	Risk of mission creep, unintended consequences, and prolonging conflict (Libya 2011 intervention led to state collapse and civil war)
Can stabilise regions, prevent refugee crises, and protect vulnerable populations	Intervening powers may have ulterior motives (resources, geopolitics, regime change) disguised as humanitarianism
Promotes universal human rights standards and holds perpetrators	Western-centric: who decides which crises merit intervention? Why intervene in Libya but not Syria, Yemen, or Myanmar?

accountable	Selective application undermines legitimacy
Economic sanctions can pressure change without military violence	Sanctions often harm ordinary citizens more than the regime they target (Iraq sanctions in the 1990s contributed to 500,000 excess child deaths according to UNICEF estimates)
ICC prosecution deters future atrocities by ending impunity	Major powers are not ICC members and refuse to submit to its jurisdiction; enforcement is impossible without state cooperation

Case Study: Rwanda Genocide (1994) — Failure to Intervene

The Rwandan genocide is the defining case of international failure to protect human rights:

- **Events:** Between April and July 1994, approximately 800,000 Tutsis and moderate Hutus were killed in just 100 days — a rate of 8,000 deaths per day. Perpetrators included the Hutu-dominated government, army, militias (Interahamwe), and ordinary citizens
- **International failure:** The UN peacekeeping force (UNAMIR, commanded by General Romeo Dallaire) was under-resourced (2,500 troops, later reduced to 270) and had a restricted mandate that prevented it from using force. Dallaire sent a fax to UN headquarters warning of genocide planning 3 months before it began — it was ignored. France, Belgium, and the USA all had intelligence but chose not to act. The Clinton administration deliberately avoided using the word "genocide" to evade the obligation to intervene under the Genocide Convention. Belgium withdrew its troops after 10 peacekeepers were killed, sending a signal that the international community would not resist
- **Aftermath:** The genocide ended when the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) under Paul Kagame took control. 2 million Hutus fled to neighbouring countries (primarily eastern DRC), destabilising the region and contributing to the First and Second Congo Wars (which killed an estimated 5.4 million people). The International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda (ICTR) was established, convicting 93 individuals including the former prime minister
- **Legacy:** Rwanda's experience directly led to the development of R2P. It demonstrated that sovereignty cannot be a shield for genocide and that the international community bears responsibility when it fails to act. Rwanda's post-genocide recovery has been remarkable: rapid economic growth (7%+ GDP growth/year); universal healthcare; women hold 61% of

parliamentary seats (highest in the world); poverty fell from 60% to 38%. But: Kagame's government is authoritarian, with severe restrictions on press freedom and political opposition

Case Study: Sanctions on North Korea — Limits of Economic Pressure

North Korea (DPRK) illustrates the limitations of sanctions as a tool for promoting human rights:

- **Human rights situation:** The UN Commission of Inquiry (2014) documented systematic violations including: political prison camps (kwanliso) holding an estimated 80,000–120,000 people; torture, execution, and forced labour; denial of freedom of movement, expression, and religion; state-controlled information (no internet access, no independent media); severe food insecurity (40% of the population chronically malnourished)
- **Sanctions regime:** Among the most comprehensive in history, targeting North Korea's nuclear weapons programme. UN Security Council resolutions ban arms trade, restrict luxury goods imports, limit oil supply, freeze assets of officials, and impose travel bans. Additional unilateral sanctions from USA, EU, Japan, and South Korea
- **Effectiveness:** Sanctions have not changed the regime's behaviour on nuclear weapons or human rights. The Kim regime prioritises its own survival over population welfare ("byungjin" policy of parallel nuclear and economic development). Sanctions are circumvented through China (which provides 90% of North Korea's trade and is reluctant to enforce sanctions fully for fear of regime collapse). Ordinary citizens bear the cost: humanitarian organisations report that sanctions restrictions impede delivery of food, medicine, and humanitarian supplies
- **Key lesson:** Sanctions can impose economic costs but cannot force regime change when the ruling elite is willing to let its population suffer. Authoritarian regimes with tight control over information and minimal civil society are particularly resistant to external pressure

Exam Tip: OCR questions frequently ask you to assess the effectiveness of different approaches to promoting human rights. Always use specific evidence from case studies, consider multiple scales (local, national, global), and weigh competing perspectives. The strongest answers: (1) evaluate multiple approaches (military intervention, sanctions, diplomacy, NGO advocacy, grassroots empowerment); (2) acknowledge that effectiveness varies by context; (3) discuss the sovereignty vs intervention tension; (4) consider whose human rights are being promoted and by whom (the

Western-centric critique); (5) recognise that progress is often incremental and contested, not linear. Avoid simplistic conclusions — show awareness of complexity and trade-offs.

8. Synoptic Links

Human rights connects to every other area of the OCR specification. The strongest answers draw these links explicitly:

- **Global governance (2.5 Power and Borders):** How international institutions (UN, ICC, EU) attempt to manage human rights, and why they often fail due to sovereignty concerns and power imbalances
- **Migration (2.3):** Refugees fleeing human rights abuses; the rights of migrants and asylum seekers; the tension between border control and human rights obligations; climate migration and the governance gap
- **Development and trade (2.2):** The relationship between poverty, inequality, and rights violations; how trade structures can perpetuate or alleviate inequality; TNCs and labour rights in global supply chains
- **Globalisation:** How global interconnections can both spread and challenge human rights norms; the role of social media in exposing abuses and mobilising campaigns; cultural globalisation and the universalism vs relativism debate
- **Climate change and hazards (1.3):** Environmental rights; climate justice (those least responsible suffer most); climate refugees and the legal protection gap; the right to a safe environment
- **Place and identity (2.1):** How state power, sovereignty, and territorial control shape which rights are protected and for whom; how place-based identity intersects with rights claims (indigenous land rights, minority rights)

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